of hiring ‘goondas to assault those who did not fall in line of his approach’. His tactics sat well with the workers and he became even more popular among them, especially after a liberal wage-hike deal he was able to prise from the management in 1982.

In the following year, Nair was suspended. But he continued to be popular among the workers and in the next union election that was held in December 1987, his nominees trumped the rival union, winning thirty-six out of the forty-two posts. The victory emboldened him and with it the workers became more militant. In June of the next year, matters took a serious turn, with the TKS warning workers not to heed the management’s directions to work overtime. One worker who disregarded the warning was assaulted.

Nair’s popularity continued to soar. In July 1988, at a specially convened general body meeting, he was elected working president of the TKS. A few TELCO employees challenged his election in court. The industrial court in Pune held that the general body meeting was not lawfully convened as Nair was a dismissed employee. It also barred him and two of his cohorts from holding their posts until the petition was finally decided. But this setback did not dent his influence over the workers who continued to disrupt work in the plants.

The management began negotiations in September 1988 to resolve the labour issues. But the workers refused to join the negotiations until Nair was recognized as their leader. By now, Ratan had been appointed deputy chairman of TELCO. He refused to accept this precondition and maintained that Nair was a dismissed employee who could not be the bona fide leader of the company workers. Nair defiantly declared that ‘the management would have to negotiate with him to bring the company back to normalcy’.

Back to the Wall

It was a trying time for Ratan. He threw everything he had into the fight. It tested his resolve and patience, as it did his courage. He reminisces that ‘it was a terrible time’ and one of the ‘loneliest moments’ of his life.

He also remembers how he got little or no support from fellow industrialists during the labour unrest. He recalls a meeting of industrialists in March 1989 in which he was virtually isolated on the issue of labour unrest. The industrialists did not want to be seen to be opposing Nair for